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Talent Acquisition Challenges in the Indian FMCG Manufacturing Sector

An Internship report submitted in partial fulfillment of requirements for
Masters of Business Administration (Human Resource)

July, 2025

Under the Guidance of Mr. Neeraj Kataria



Internal Guide:

Mr. Neeraj Kataria

Proctor and Associate Professor,

School of Business, UPES

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Submitted by

Pratishtha Naithani

SAP id: 590016882

Enrollment Number: 24010310951

MBACore

2024-2026

School of Business, UPES

Student Declaration

I hereby declare that this submission is my own work and that, to the best of my knowledge and belief, it contains no material previously published or written by another person nor material which has been accepted for the award of any other degree or diploma of the university or other institute of higher learning, except where due acknowledgment has been made in the text.

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SAP Id: 590016882

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2024-2026

School of Business, UPES

Acknowledgement

I want to express my heartfelt gratitude to all those who supported and guided me throughout my summer internship and the completion of this research project.

First and foremost, I am deeply thankful to my industry mentor, Mr. Sandeep Kumar, HR Manager, for his continuous guidance, encouragement, and constructive feedback during the internship. I also extend my sincere gratitude to my faculty mentor, Mr. Neeraj Kataria, Proctor and Associate Professor at the School of Business, UPES, for his valuable academic support and insightful suggestions throughout this journey.

I would like to acknowledge the unwavering support and cooperation of the organisation's heads, including Mr. Madan Mohan Mungali, Plant Head and Head of the Quality Department; Mr. Keshav Upadhyay, Plant Head and Production Head; and Mr. Arush Agarwal, Managing Director and Owner of the Company. Their leadership and willingness to share valuable insights played a pivotal role in the successful completion of my project.

I am also grateful to my colleagues from both the industry and university, whose valuable suggestions and constructive criticisms helped shape the direction and quality of this research.

Special thanks are due to the executives from various departments who generously provided relevant data and literature, which formed the foundation of my research analysis.

Lastly, I extend my appreciation to the typesetting office and its personnel for their assistance in formatting and preparing this report for submission.

**FARMS2FREEZE FOODS PRIVATE LIMITED**

Registered Office: Building situated at Khasra No 245 Patanjali Food & Herbal Park,
Village Padartha Haridwar, and Uttarakhand – 249404
CIN: U10306UT2023PTC015874, Email Id: hr@hungryyfoods.com

Model Industry Mentors certificate

This is to certify that the summer internship report entitled:

'Talent Acquisition Challenges in the Indian FMCG Manufacturing Sector"

submitted by Pratishtha Naithani to UPES for partial fulfillment of requirements for Masters of Business Administration (Human Resource) is a bonafide record of the internship work carried out by her/him under my (our) supervision and guidance. The content of the report, in full or parts has not been submitted to any other Institute or University for the award of any other degree or diploma.

FARMS2FREEZE FOODS PRIVATE LIMITED

Mr. Sandeep Kumar

HR Manager

Farms2freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd.

Patanjali Food and Herbal Park

**FARMS2FREEZE FOODS PRIVATE LIMITED**

Registered Office: Building situated at Khasra No 245 Patanjali Food & Herbal Park,
Village Padartha Haridwar, and Uttarakhand – 249404
CIN: U10306UT2023PTC015874, Email Id: hr@hungryyfoods.com

Ref No- F2F/HR/TC/2025/06**Date: 31st July-2025****Internship Completion Certificate**

This is to certify that Ms. Pratishtha Naithani has done her summer internship with Patanjali in Farm2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd., which is an RTE and frozen food plant, from 16/06/2025 and has completed her summer internship titled:

“Talent Acquisition Challenges in the Indian FMCG Manufacturing Sector”

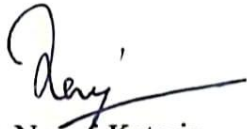
on **31/07/2025**. She has submitted a copy of her report to the organisation on **28/07/2025** and has given a presentation to the organization on **31/07/2025**.

She was found to be very good, sincere, and efficient in her work and we wish her all the best for her future endeavors.

FARMS2FREEZE FOODS PRIVATE LIMITED
Authorized Signatory**Mr. Sandeep Kumar****HR Manager****Farms2freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd.****Patanjali Food and Herbal Park**

MENTOR CERTIFICATE**Certificate**

This is to certify that the summer internship report entitled "Talent Acquisition Challenges in the Indian FMCG Manufacturing Sector" submitted by Pratishtha Naithani to UPES for partial fulfillment of requirements for Masters of Business Administration (Human Resource) is a bonafide record of the internship work carried out by her/him under my (our) supervision and guidance. The content of the report, in full or parts have not been submitted to any other Institute or University for the award of any other degree or diploma.



Mr. Neeraj Kataria

Proctor and Associate Professor,
School of Business, UPES

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This report offers a thorough analysis of Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd.'s talent acquisition issues, a joint venture of Patanjali that produces frozen and ready-to-eat "Hungryy" brand foods. The prime aim was to examine the recruitment, induction, and retention cycles at the factory level, with special emphasis on the management of on-roll and off-roll manpower in the highly competitive and fast-changing Indian FMCG manufacturing industry. The investigation observed considerable difficulty in sourcing and retaining qualified shopfloor workers in the semi-urban setting, technology demands, and growing regulatory and safety compliance expectations. Increased reliance on contractors to address fluctuating manpower needs subjects the plant to excessive turnover, substandard training, notice period abuse, and variable compliance with statutory benefits and plant safety and hygiene SOPs. These compliance requirements, though imperative for operational integrity and regulatory compliance, sometimes cause short-term attrition as employees adapt to stricter standards and procedures. Rollout of the HRCONNECKT digital platform enhanced payroll accuracy and compliance tracking but underscored continued issues with manual intervention and limited-user training. The retention issue is exacerbated by poor visibility of career progression, operations pressures, and communication breakdowns, particularly among contract and blue-collar workers. To address these, the report suggests diversification of recruitment sources through vocational schools and local outreach, automation of statutory documentation for all types of workers, enhancement of induction and multilingual training programs emphasizing safety and compliance, and implementation of strict contractor audits. Employer branding and transparent career paths will enhance better worker engagement and retention. The conclusions, drawn from actual experience within recruitment rounds, compliance audits, and induction processes throughout the internship, provide Farms2Freeze and other FMCG manufacturers with actionable recommendations to maintain competitive edge through a stable, skilled, and compliant workforce. The recommendations, if implemented, will balance business needs, regulatory demands, and the welfare of employees to position the business as an employer of choice in a challenging labor market.

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION



Patanjali Ayurved Limited (PAL) is a unique social business endeavor dedicated to providing pure, affordable, and green products and services to the masses. Founded in 2006 by Acharya Balkrishna ji and Yogrishi Swami Ramdev ji Maharaj, Patanjali is not just an ordinary company—it is a revolutionary concept towards liberating Indian consumers from the grip of multinational companies with a tendency to market high-cost, spurious, and unhealthy products. Rooted in strong values of nationalism, Ayurveda, and Yoga, PAL's vision is to create a healthier nation through the blending of ancient wisdom with the most advanced scientific practices. The company is a vehicle of economic emancipation, with special focus on empowering rural masses and countering the ill effects of urbanization. Driven by underlying values of 'Sewa' (unselfish service), 'Samarpan' (dedication), 'Sanskriti' (cultural values), and 'Santulan' (sustainability and equilibrium), Patanjali works towards making India a world leader in Ayurveda and integral well-being.

Simultaneously, Capital Ventures, established so many years ago in 1970 as a commodity trading house in Punjab, India, grew into a worldwide exporter that supplied more than 70 countries with more than 15,000 products. Its shift from commodity trading to world exports provided the foundation for innovative joint ventures to meet the demands of the modern day consumer.

The Patanjali Ayurved Limited-Capital Ventures joint venture introduces the "Hungryy" brand, a blend of tradition and technology offering true, high-quality frozen and ready-to-eat foods like samosas, naan, spring rolls, and ready-to-cook dal chawal. Utilizing cutting-edge Shelf Stable and Individually Quick Frozen (IQF) technologies, Farms2Freeze freezes each product with its traditional taste, freshness, and texture while meeting contemporary food safety guidelines. The company uses world-class manufacturing facilities to serve the changing palates of fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) markets, especially India's increasing urban and semi-urban markets.

The high-growth Indian FMCG market with its vibrant consumerism and increasing technological absorption is the pillar of the economy of the nation. Patanjali and Farms2Freeze are at the forefront of the revolution, blending cultural authenticity with production expertise to meet rising demand for packaged food with quality. Growth, however, brings humongous talent sourcing challenges—especially at the plant level where the proper manpower to operate hi-tech equipment and enforce strict quality and safety standards.

The sophisticated nature of FMCG production, especially in frozen and ready-to-eat food lines, demands a technically qualified as well as extremely adaptable human resource base to grapple with regimes of control, plant safety protocols, and production continuity imperatives. In such a scenario, the use of contract employees and off-roll staff to deal with fluctuating production demands is not unusual, but such reliance causes problems like excessive turnover of staff, inadequate skill, too little training, and compliance issues with plant-specific SOPs and statutory labor legislation. A further exacerbating factor is talent acquisition and retention in rural or semi-urban locations, augmented by competitive labor markets and shifting employee behavior. Acknowledging these talent acquisition challenges, especially in the case of Farms2Freeze and the business model of Patanjali, is critical. Not only does it reflect the overall employee concerns being faced by India's FMCG manufacturing sector but also offers a glimpse into strategic HR approaches needed to ensure sustained growth, foster quality, and optimize productivity. The detailed analysis in this article will emphasize these facts, bridge the gaps between traditional HR practices and evolving industry needs, and facilitate the development of a robust, competent, and compliant workforce able to drive the ambitious agenda of these organizations.

CHAPTER 2: OVERVIEW OF THE ORGANISATION'S HISTORY, MISSION, PRODUCTS/SERVICES, INDUSTRY, AND MARKET POSITION



Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd. is an innovative joint venture between Patanjali Ayurved Limited and Capital Ventures, established to deliver high-quality, authentic, and affordable frozen and ready-to-eat food products to consumers in India and abroad. Patanjali Ayurved Limited was established by Acharya Balkrishna ji with Yogrishi Swami Ramdev ji Maharaj in 2006 as a distinct social business that aspires to deliver high quality, affordable, pure and environmentally friendly products to people. Patanjali's unique philosophy integrates Ayurveda, Yoga, Indian traditional context, and a nationalist spirit for the wellbeing of people and the sustainable development of society as a whole.

On the other side, Capital Ventures is a global trading and exporting giant with over five decades of legacy, operating in 70 country (and counting) with a vast portfolio of 15,000+ products. Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd. came into being by combining Patanjali's cultural heritage, wellness knowledge and Capital Ventures global supply chain and export capabilities to take the best of India's traditional recipes to world with modern food processing methods.

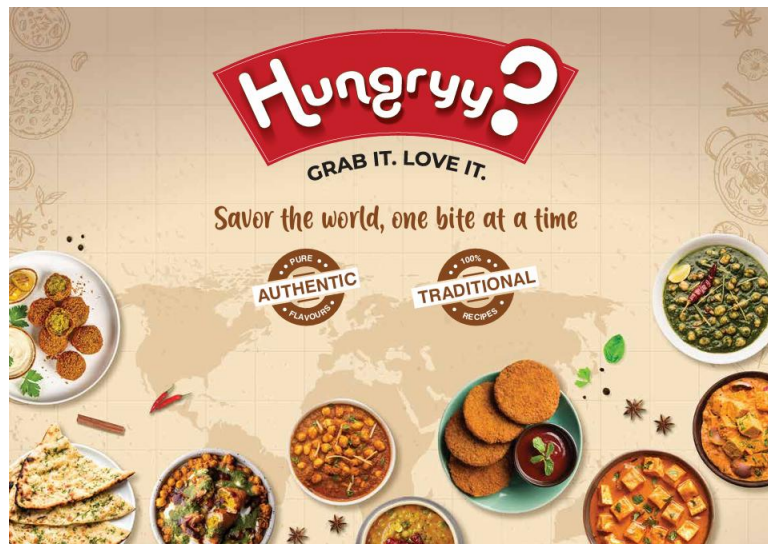
They operate under the brand name Hungryy. Their focus is producing ready-to-eat (RTE) and frozen food products that meet modern consumer requirements in terms of convenience, taste,

and health. Farms2Freeze has a world-class manufacturing facility using Shelf Stable and Individually Quick Frozen (IQF) technologies which assure that every product is offered in its best possible freshness, nutrition, and true flavor. Their plant is truly does meet the highest levels of food safety and hygiene, thus making it a serious player in the Indian fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) manufacturing sector.

Industry & Market Position:

Farms2Freeze operates in the booming Indian FMCG and food processing sector and is expected to be worth \$220 billion by 2025. The market for frozen and RTE foods has grown, as modern retail grows, urbanization is through the roof, dual income households are rising, and demand for convenience foods are on the rise. Farms2Freeze has built a reputation for quality, variety, and regulatory compliance and services both the domestic and export markets. The company serves retail consumers all the way to industrial buyers and quick-serve restaurants customers. The company supplies most major cities of India and is entering international markets. The company emphasizes its commitment to tradition and innovation.

Products of Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd. (Hungryy Brand)



Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd., under the Hungryy brand, offers an impressive range of frozen and ready-to-eat products, blending traditional Indian recipes with state-of-the-art food technology. The products are diversified to cater to varied regional palates and include:

Product Table

Category	Product Name
Samosa	Pizza Samosa
	Beetroot Corn Samosa
	Punjabi Rocket Samosa
	Paneer Chilli Cocktail Samosa
	Spinach & Corn Cocktail Samosa
	Cheese & Jalapeno Cocktail Samosa
	Assorted Cocktail Samosas
	Beetroot Cocktail Samosa
	Potato Schezwan Cocktail Samosa
	Punjabi Cocktail Samosa
	Punjabi Samosa
	Punjabi Samosa Family Pack
	Achari Aloo Samosa
	Jumbo Punjabi Samosa
	Jumbo Punjabi Samosa Family Pack
	Potli Samosa

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Category	Product Name
	Pinwheel Punjabi Samosa
	Twister Punjabi Samosa
Breads / Paratha	Aloo Pyaz Paratha
	Aloo Pyaz Paratha Family Pack
	Aloo Paratha
	Aloo Paratha Family Pack
	Lachha Paratha
	Lachha Paratha Family Pack
	Home Style Paratha
	Home Style Paratha Family Pack
	Palak Mutter Paneer Paratha
	Beetroot Paratha
	Gobi Paratha
	Paneer Paratha
	Mix Veg Paratha
	Pudina Lachha Paratha
	Methi Paratha
	Onion Paratha

Talent Acquisition Challenges in the Indian FMCG Manufacturing Sector

Category	Product Name
	Dal Paratha
	Ajwain Paratha
	Garlic Butter Naan
	Garlic Butter Naan Family Pack
	Tandoori Naan
	Tandoori Naan Family Pack
	Chilli Garlic Butter Naan
	Phulka Roti
Curries	Palak Paneer
	Paneer Makhani
	Kadai Methi Palak Paneer
	Paneer Butter Masala
	Kadhai Paneer
	Rajma Masala
	Punjabi Kadhi Pakoda With Basmati Rice
	Dal Makhani
	Punjabi Rajma With Basmati Rice
	Dal Tadka

Talent Acquisition Challenges in the
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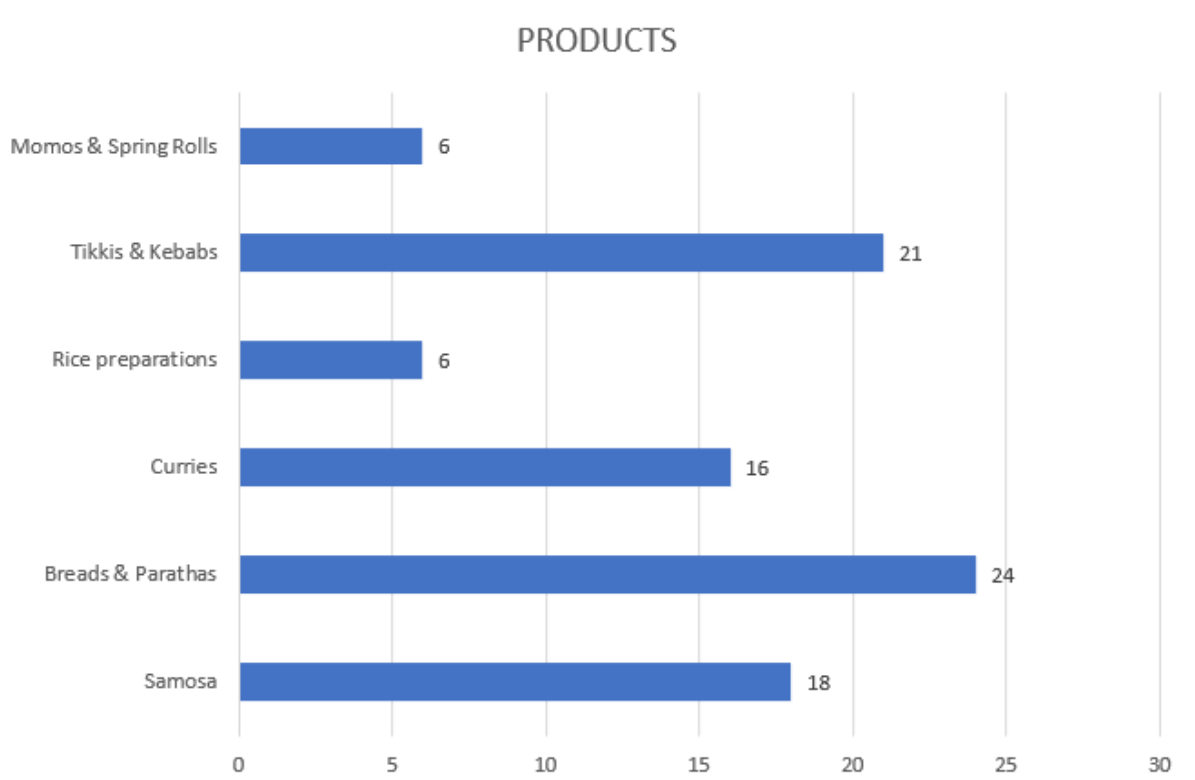
Category	Product Name
	Dal Makhani With Basmati Rice
	Amritsari Chole
	Amritsari Chole With Basmati Rice
	Punjabi Kadhi Pakoda
	Malai Kofta
	Sarson Ka Saag
Rice	Basmati Rice
	Lemon Rice
	Brown Basmati Rice
	Hyderabadi Dum Biryani
	Turmeric Basmati Rice
Tikki	Aloo Tikki
	Aloo Tikki Family Pack
	Amritsari Tangy Chilli Tikki
	Ragda Patty
Kebab	Beetroot Kebab
	Spinach Quinoa Kebab
	Rajma Galouti Kebab

**Talent Acquisition Challenges in the
Indian FMCG Manufacturing Sector**

Category	Product Name
	Vegetable Burger Patty
	Vegetable Seekh Kebab
	Railway Cutlet
	Shami Kebab
	Lebanese Falafel Kebab
	Hara Bhara Kebab
	Millet Shami Kebab
	Foxtail Millet Shami Kebab
	Barnyard Millet Kebab
	Millet Methi Kebab
	Dahi Ke Kebab
	Makai Galouti Kebab
	Beetroot with Cheese Amla Amouranth Kebab
	Hara Bhara Kebab with Cheese and Moringa
Momos	Paneer Momos
	Vegetable Momos
	Tandoori Vegetable Momos
	Spinach & Paneer Momos

Talent Acquisition Challenges in the Indian FMCG Manufacturing Sector

Category	Product Name
Spring Roll	Chilli Paneer Spring Roll
	Vegetable Spring Roll



CHAPTER 3: OVERVIEW OF THE INDIAN FMCG SECTOR: GROWTH TRENDS, FUTURE PROJECTIONS, AND MAJOR PLAYERS

The Indian Fast-Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) industry is a significant contributor to employment and national GDP and is one of the largest and most dynamic sectors of the Indian economy. By 2025, it is expected to account for approximately \$220 billion, with continuing strong annual compound growth rates of around 14 to 16%. Numerous factors are propelling this growth, including a rapidly expanding middle class, an increase in disposable income, rapid urbanization, and an increase in dual-income households, leading to a higher demand for convenience-oriented FMCG product categories such as packaged food, ready-to-eat meals, and frozen snacks.

The FMCG space is characterized by high competition, rapid innovation, and the increased influence of health and wellness trends. The digital revolution and e-commerce have transformed supply chains and consumer engagement, making an omnichannel approach more important than ever. Finally, government initiatives aimed towards food processing and rural area development have increased consumer reach and improved the infrastructure as well.

Major Players:

With global players and strong Indian brands like Hindustan Unilever (HUL), Nestlé India, ITC Ltd., Britannia Industries, Dabur, and Patanjali Ayurved Limited - all of which are well known for brand reliability, distribution channels, and assortment of products - the segment is indeed competitive. Patanjali offers a mix of Ayurvedic angle, low-cost offerings, and commitment to product purity and sustainability, making a meaningful differentiation in the food industry.

Growth & Future Scenarios:

The sector is likely to continue double-digit growth rate in food and beverages driven by increased rural market penetration, rise in health-consciousness, innovation in product categories (for example ready-to-eat/frozen food) and the rapid transition to yet untapped Tier II and Tier III markets. The formalization movement from government efforts is guiding regulatory relevance, compliance, and food safety to drive regulatory...a lot of change in the workforce function/processes in the industry, the sourcing and HR functions and processes need to be able to respond with agility.

CHAPTER 4: COMPETITIVE ANALYSIS: WHERE DOES FARMS2FREEZE (HUNGRIYY) STAND?

Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd. is strategically positioned at the intersection of tradition and innovation. As a joint venture between Patanjali Ayurved Limited and Capital Ventures, it leverages Patanjali's powerful wellness-focused branding and extensive distribution alongside Capital Ventures' supply chain and global export acumen.

Product Offering:

Farms2Freeze's "Hungryy" brand offers a unique, all-vegetarian portfolio of frozen and ready-to-eat foods (samosas, parathas, tikkis, kebabs, curries, rice, momos, and spring rolls), merging authentic Indian flavors with modern processing (IQF and retort technology). This combination allows the company to meet the rising demand for convenience, quality, and health in urban, semi-urban, and export markets.

Market Position:

While leading FMCG majors (like HUL and ITC) hold extensive portfolios and dominate the national market, Hungryy's differentiation comes from:

- Patanjali's trusted Ayurveda and health-oriented brand equity
- Exclusive focus on vegetarian, high-quality, and hygienic products
- Strong emphasis on traditional Indian flavors and sustainable sourcing
- Growing presence in both domestic cities and international markets via Capital Ventures' network

Competitive Edge:

- Farms2Freeze benefits from the parentage of two established organizations, which provides operational stability and funding for innovation.
- Its expertise in Indian culinary innovation helps in capturing a niche health-conscious segment.
- Efficient plant operations and adherence to global compliance standards (supported by HR digitalization) improve reliability and consumer trust.

SWOT Analysis for Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd.

Strengths	Weakness
Backed by Patanjali and Capital Ventures: Financial and brand strength	Relatively new in a market with entrenched competitors
Exclusive, innovative, vegetarian-only product portfolio	Still building national and international brand awareness
Modern manufacturing (IQF, retort, automation) with strict SOPs	Occasional skill shortages and high attrition, especially among contract staff
Integrated supply chain and export capability Enables wide distribution	Dependence on agency/contractual labor creates operational instability
Rapid adaptation to digital platforms (HR, MIS, compliance)	Limited product awareness outside North/Northwest India

Opportunities	Threats
Rising demand for healthy, convenient, and ethnic frozen/RTE foods	Fierce competition from large FMCG and regional players
Expansion into Tier II/III cities and overseas Indian diaspora markets	Regulatory tightening (food safety, labor laws) could impact operations
Leveraging Patanjali's "trusted Ayurvedic" positioning for new launches	Inflation and raw material price volatility affecting margins
Partnership with hotels, restaurants, and cloud kitchens	Consumer shift toward home-cooked/organic alternatives post-pandemic
Innovations via NPD (millet-based, vegan, fusion products)	Ongoing workforce retention and upskilling challenges in semi-urban setting

With its foundation in tradition and commitment to purity, combined with investment in quality, automation, and modern HR practices, Farms2Freeze is poised to be a key disruptive force in the Indian and global frozen foods market. Nevertheless, success hinges on consolidating market presence, strengthening the talent pipeline, ensuring compliance, and maintaining agile operations in response to fast-changing industry and consumer trends.

CHAPTER 5: REVIEW OF LITERATURE

The domain of Human Resources is pivotal for aligning workforce management with broader organizational goals, especially in the context of India's fast-growing and highly competitive Fast-Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) sector. Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd., a joint venture of Patanjali Ayurved Limited and Capital Ventures, operates within this dynamic landscape, where the effective implementation of HR practices—particularly talent acquisition, employee engagement, compliance, and workforce development—is not only essential but also transformative for long-term growth and plant stability.

Talent Acquisition in Manufacturing/Plant Contexts:

Modern literature asserts that talent acquisition is a holistic strategy that extends beyond traditional recruitment to include workforce forecasting, employer branding, and candidate experience management (Dessler, 2017). In the FMCG manufacturing space, effective talent acquisition is challenged by factors such as plant location, skill shortages for specialized equipment, and seasonal fluctuations in labor demand (Armstrong, 2019). Prospective planning of the workforce, or prediction of skills required today and for the future, is a characteristic of best HR departments, according to Lepak and Gowan (2010). This holds particularly for companies like Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd., whose needs change continuously during operations and scalability of production depends on timely access to skilled and compliant workers.

Employer Branding and Candidate Attraction:

A study by Backhaus and Tikoo (2004) and recent HR studies indicate that employer branding plays a key role in the attraction and retention of the best talent and this is especially in the case of direct. there is a competition with MNCs and players in the industry. For semi-urban or rural-based plants, the literature highlights the need to communicate a strong employee value proposition, providing definite career growth avenues, and assimilation of local community. engagement programs to iqmotify the work place (Jiang, 2011). Given The specialization of Farms2Freeze- they are in between tradition, wellness, and modern packaged. foods- HR can use this identity to improve its attractiveness among both blue-collar candidates. and technical specialists.

Challenges in Contractual and Off-Roll Hiring:

There is plenty of literature on the risks and management (Brewster et al., 2016). complexities of high dependency on contract and off-roll labor. Studies indicate that such dependency may cause such problems as irregular training, decreased commitment, compliance. discontinuities, and turnover,--common in Indian manufacturing sites. HR measures like frequent audit of contractor practices, standard induction, and clear expression of legal advantages are suggested as the ways of alleviating these risks. (Kalleberg, 2009; Srivastava & Agarwal, 2020).

Onboarding and Integration:

The onboarding process has also long been posited as integral to early reductions in attrition and facilitating

by workers (Bauer, 2010). Also, research has shown that multilingual, well onboarding programs—that are compatible with the level of education and host employees' preferred languages—may help promote awareness regarding workplace expectations, compliance requirements, and safety measures (Klein & Polin, 2012). In a production environment like Farms2Freeze, where operational integrity requires strict adherence to SOPs for hygiene, safety, and production quality, a best practice is integrating compliance training and culture-building aspects from day one.

Employee Engagement and Retention:

Multiple scholars—including Kahn (1990), Saks (2006), and Bakker & Demerouti (2008)—have established that engaged employees are more productive, experience lower turnover, and actively contribute to continuous improvement programs. In manufacturing, engagement is linked not just to payroll and benefits, but also to workplace safety, opportunities for advancement, participative problem-solving, and recognition of contributions. Today's HR best practices, as described by Schaufeli et al. (2002), encourage the use of employee suggestion drives, safety campaigns, and structured feedback loops to enhance commitment, particularly among blue-collar and contract staff.

Compliance, Payroll Management, and Ethics:

Maintaining compliance with statutory regulations (e.g., PF, ESI, wage codes) is a cornerstone of responsible HRM, directly linked to organizational ethics and sustainability (Mathis & Jackson, 2019; Snape et al., 2000). The literature recommends rigorous documentation, regular audits, and digital solutions for payroll processing and benefit disbursement to reduce risk and maintain trust (Stone et al., 2015). Farms2Freeze's adoption of digital HR platforms like HRKconnect aligns with industry trends outlined by DeLisi & Daugherty (2022), supporting timely, auditable, and transparent HR operations.

Workplace Safety, SOPs, and Operational Excellence:

Research specific to manufacturing (Vinodkumar & Bhasi, 2010) underscores the sustained value of safety-oriented culture and compliance-driven SOPs—not just for accident prevention, but also for improving morale, reducing absenteeism, and supporting consistent quality. Embedding these standards into HR-led training and recognition programs is shown to drive both compliance and engagement.

Technology and Skills Development:

The evolving HR landscape increasingly prioritizes upskilling and digital literacy (Ulrich et al., 2017), echoing the need for HR practitioners to integrate HRIS tools, digital documentation, and e-learning into everyday practice. Literature depicts the dual elements of soft skills and technical skills development in relation to operational agility, workforce agility and plant innovation (Stone et al., 2015; Becker & Huselid, 2006). This literature illustrates the broad HR roles underpinning my internship experience at Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd and situates the real-life challenges of contract management, skills gaps, compliance, HR technology, and working in an industrial environment.

The theoretical basis from authors including Dessler, Armstrong, Kahn, and Mathis provided the knowledge base for the practical solutions and recommendations I implemented for

Talent Acquisition Challenges in the Indian FMCG Manufacturing Sector

example, better recruitment practices, introduction to onboarding and compliance processes, and HR technology. Altogether, this literature gives a more fully rounded perspective of the dynamic HR requirements of modern FMCG manufacturing organizations such as Farms2Freeze.

CHAPTER 6: OVERVIEW OF RESEARCH METHODOLOGIES

The research methodology for this report is supported by a wealth of practical experience gained through my internship at Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd., which provided an immersive and practical experience of the entire human resources cycle in an FMCG manufacturing context. This practice linked specific action learning around tasks I was directly involved with—for example, recruitment and onboarding, the learning and induction process, keeping HR records, and the performance management system—with live observation of the array of activities conducted in the plant, alongside ongoing compliance reviews.

Data was collected through quantitative approaches, such as managing candidate shortlisting, onboarding the new staff members, electronic personnel file preparation, and documents relating to audit for human resource management; qualitative exposure addressed structured inductions, safety inspections, and hygiene incentives, employee engagement initiatives, and working with /leading the plant and HR teams, to name just a few. The methodology also encompassed participation in mandatory compliance processes, applying human resources policies, and using a digital human resources approach, all of which collectively offered the basis of the report's analysis in an authentic, practical context.

Continuous reflection on each responsibility, combined with systematic understanding of plant SOPs, participation in industrial visits, and cross-functional collaboration, ensured that the research addressed not only procedural aspects but also brought out the underlying practical challenges and strategic insights relevant to talent acquisition and retention within the Indian FMCG sector.

1. Objectives of the Research Methodology

The primary objective of the research methodology was to gain practical exposure to end-to-end HR operations within the FMCG manufacturing sector. The focus was on comprehending, applying, and analyzing talent acquisition, onboarding, statutory compliance, HR policy implementation, and employee engagement strategies at Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd.

2. Approach and Scope

The methodology combined experiential learning and direct participation in day-to-day HR activities at the Farms2Freeze manufacturing plant during a six-week internship. The approach encompassed involvement with core HR functions—recruitment, onboarding, training, employee records management, statutory compliance, and industrial relations—paired with observation of plant operations and cross-departmental coordination.

3. Data Collection Methods

A mixed-methods approach was used to gather both quantitative and qualitative data:

- **Quantitative Data:** Screening over 100 candidate profiles, scheduling and conducting 50+ interviews, onboarding more than 20 new employees, digitizing in excess of 60 personnel files, and managing HR data for 100+ plant staff.

- Qualitative Data: Observed and facilitated structured induction programs, training sessions, safety drills, employee satisfaction surveys, engagement campaigns, and compliance audits. Regular reflection on interactions and problem-solving within the HR and plant environment enriched qualitative insights.

4. Projects and Activities Undertaken

Key responsibilities and exposures included:

- Assisting with end-to-end recruitment and onboarding processes.
- Coordinating and facilitating training and induction sessions for new hires and existing staff.
- Maintaining, updating, and digitizing the HR database and confidential employee records.
- Conducting safety, hygiene, and compliance inspections on the shop floor; leading health and safety awareness campaigns.
- Supporting the Performance Management System (PMS), including data compilation and Management Information System (MIS) report generation.
- Running employee engagement initiatives, such as suggestion drives and satisfaction surveys.
- Participating in industrial relations activities and managing shift scheduling and grievance handling processes.

5. Tools and Techniques Utilized

A range of HR tools and systems were leveraged to streamline and document the methodology:

- Used HRKconnect software for employee database management, record digitization, and statutory documentation.
- Utilized Excel for MIS reporting, payroll, salary structuring, and compliance tracking.
- Applied standard operating procedures (SOPs) for recruitment, induction, training, statutory computations, and plant safety/hygiene.
- Participated in the use and understanding of ERP and MRP systems for enhancing cross-functional synergy.

6. Achievements and Quantitative Outcomes

- Screened over 100 candidate resumes and applications for multiple roles.
- Scheduled and facilitated more than 50 interviews, both telephonic and in-person.
- Successfully assisted in onboarding documentation and induction of 20+ employees.
- Digitized and managed records for more than 60 employees to support compliance and audit readiness.

- Conducted safety and compliance awareness drives, and participated in industrial outreach for 50+ student visitors.
- Actively supported the PMS appraisal process for all plant staff.

7. Learning and Reflection Process

Ongoing self-reflection was integral to the research methodology. Continuous feedback from mentors and colleagues, documentation of daily learnings, and regular assessment of project outcomes reinforced my understanding of the challenges and best practices in industrial HR management. The iterative process identified both strengths (communication, HR systems proficiency, induction programs) and areas for further improvement (advanced analytics, strategic recruitment, deeper compliance expertise).

8. Limitations

As this research was conducted within the span of a six-week internship at a single manufacturing unit, findings are context-specific and reflect the working practices of Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd. While the sample size (100+ candidates, 50+ interviews, etc.) ensured meaningful exposure, broader generalizations may require further industry-wide study.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

1. Sample Design

The sample design defines the framework used to select a subset of candidates, employees, and HR records from the entire workforce at Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd. for detailed study and analysis during the internship. This ensures that the insights gathered about recruitment, onboarding, compliance, and talent management reflect the broader realities of the plant's labor force.

- The sample included diverse employee categories, ranging from shopfloor operators and technicians to contract/off-roll staff, HR personnel, and plant managers.
- It covered various departments such as production, quality assurance, HR, and stores, ensuring representation of multiple roles and operational layers within the manufacturing ecosystem.
- This heterogeneous sampling captured variations in compliance adherence, skill levels, turnover behavior, and HR policy impacts across the workforce.

2. Sampling Method

The sampling method refers to the approach used to choose individuals and records from Farms2Freeze's workforce and HR database for detailed examination.

- Stratified Sampling: Employees were stratified by their employment type (on-roll vs. off-roll/contract), department (production, QA, HR, others), and seniority (junior staff

to supervisors), enabling focused analysis of each subgroup's talent acquisition and retention dynamics.

- **Convenience Sampling:** For some operational and compliance observations (like safety inspections and induction sessions), convenience sampling was employed, leveraging available workers and sessions during the internship period.
- **Purposive Sampling:** Selected HR records and candidate pools involved purposive sampling to focus on recent recruits, attrition cases (especially employees leaving within the first week), and compliance documentation for statutory audits.

3. Population Measure

The population measure indicates the total workforce considered for the study within the plant.

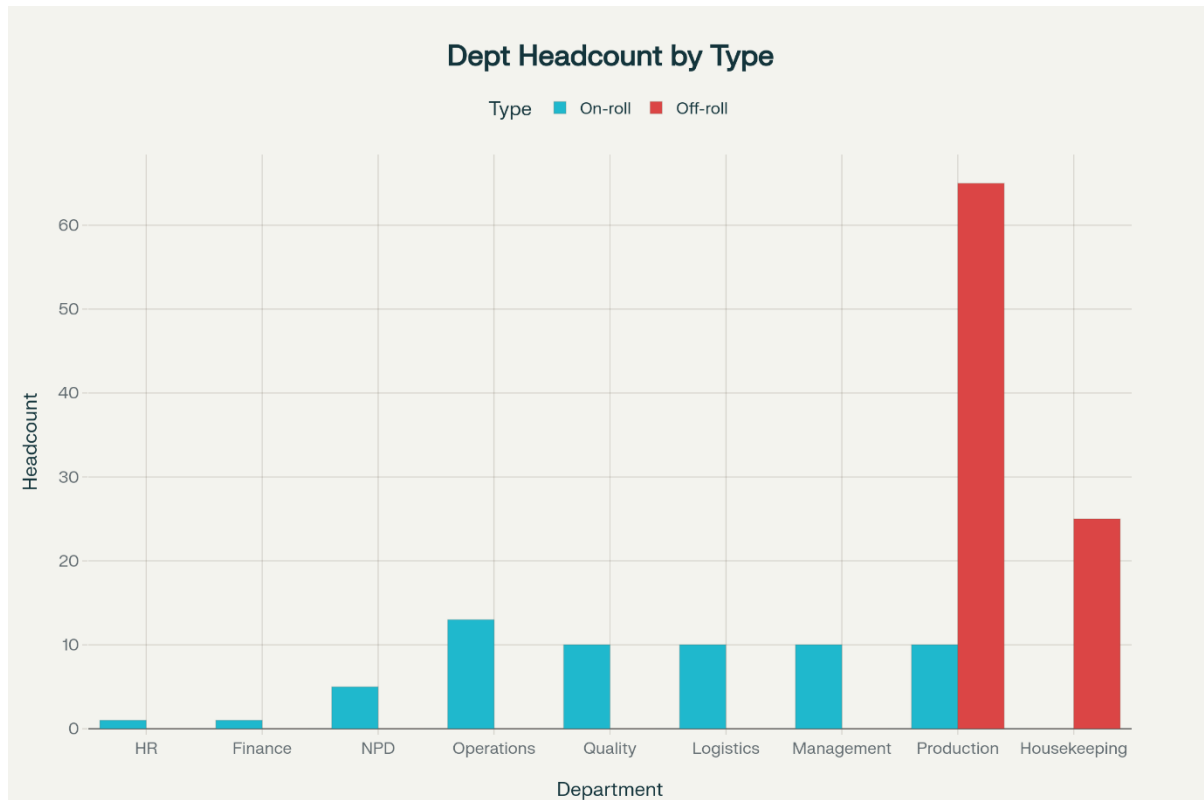
- The population encompassed the entire Farms2Freeze plant workforce—60 employees working across production, quality, stores, and administrative functions during the internship.
- Both on-roll and off-roll employees were included, with contract labor representing a significant segment due to seasonal production demands.

Department	On-roll	Off-roll (Contract)	Contractor Source
HR	1	0	—
Finance	1	0	—
NPD	5	0	—
Operations	13	0	—
Quality	10	0	—
Logistics	10	0	—
Management	10	0	—
Production	10	65	Maa Kamakhya Ltd.

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Department	On-roll	Off-roll (Contract)	Contractor Source
Housekeeping	0	25	Alpine Bath Pvt. Ltd.

- The study also involved departmental HR staff responsible for recruitment, training, compliance, and plant safety.



4. Sample Size

The sample size indicates the actual number of subjects and records examined for analysis during the internship.

- Over 100 candidates' resumes were screened as part of recruitment activities.
- More than 50 interviews (telephonic and face-to-face) were coordinated and facilitated by the HR team and internship support.
- Onboarding documentation and induction processes covered 20+ new hires during the study period.
- Digitization and management of personnel records were conducted for over 60 employees to support compliance and audit requirements.

Talent Acquisition Challenges in the Indian FMCG Manufacturing Sector

- Safety and hygiene compliance inspections involved direct interactions with staff across shifts and departments, covering a representative cross-section of the plant workforce.

Talent Acquisition Activity	Count
Resumes Screened	100
Interviews Conducted	50
Onboarded Employees	20
Digitized Employee Records	60
Student Visitors Engaged	50

CHAPTER 7 SOURCE OF DATA COLLECTION AND DATA ANALYSIS

The data collected during the internship was primarily sourced from direct, first-hand exposure to HR operations and plant activities—qualitative and quantitative in nature—rather than secondary archival data. Key data collection methods included:

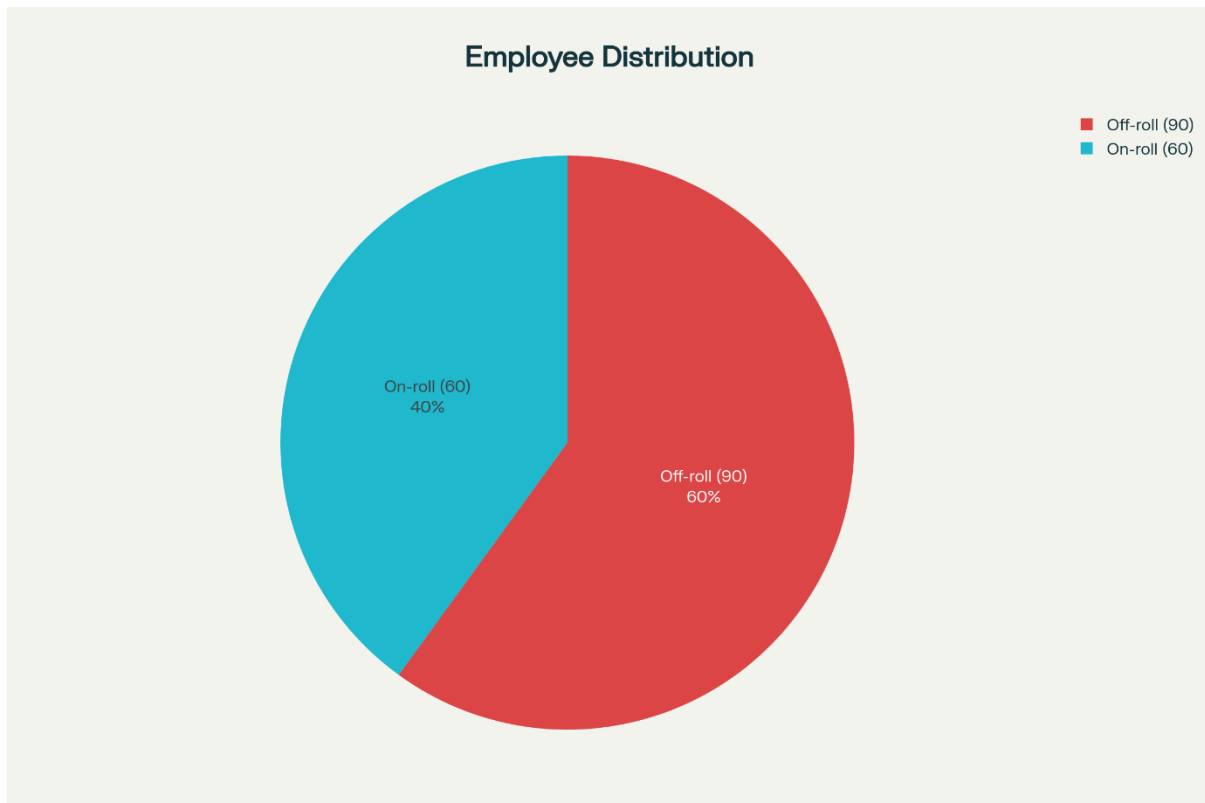
- **Surveys and Questionnaires:** Structured feedback forms from training sessions, induction programs, and employee engagement surveys helped gauge satisfaction, compliance awareness, and training effectiveness.
- **HR Records and Documentation:** Personnel files, recruitment sheets, candidate databases, interview schedules, and compliance checklists were systematically reviewed and updated.
- **Observation and Compliance Audits:** Day-to-day monitoring of safety protocols, hygiene inspections, statutory compliance adherence (PF, ESI, gratuity), and SOP implementation on the shop floor formed an essential data source.
- **Interviews and Interaction:** Direct interactions with HR managers, department heads, contract workers, and new recruits provided contextual insights into workforce challenges and HR practices

Data Analysis & Interpretation

Workforce Composition Analysis

The workforce composition at Farms2Freeze is distinctly skewed towards off-roll (contract) employees, who make up the majority of the staff, while on-roll (permanent) employees form a significant but smaller segment. Supervisors and management staff account for much smaller portions of the overall workforce. This distribution highlights a strong operational reliance on contract labor for day-to-day manufacturing activities, reflecting industry practices but also posing unique HR challenges regarding stability, compliance, and retention.

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Attrition Causes Analysis

A focused analysis was conducted to determine the key causes of employee turnover during the internship period. As part of the HR operations, feedback from exit interviews, ongoing staff observations, and review of resumes were systematically evaluated. The findings revealed that:

- Skill mismatch and non-compliance with SOPs/regulations were virtually non-existent due to effective candidate screening, comprehensive induction, and strong compliance culture on the shop floor.
- Perceptions of poor working conditions were negligible, supported by frequent health check-ups, robust safety protocols, and a clean work environment ensured by daily checks and sanitary station installations.
- The primary cause of attrition was early exit by contractual employees, reflecting the unique challenges associated with reliance on off-roll labor in the manufacturing sector. Other factors included personal reasons and external opportunities, but these were less significant.

This distribution is represented in the table (and accompanying pie chart, if required) below:

Talent Acquisition Challenges in the Indian FMCG Manufacturing Sector

Cause	Percentage
Early Exit by Contractual Employees	70%
Skill Mismatch	0%
Non-compliance with SOPs/Regulations	0%
Poor Working Conditions Perception	0%
Other Causes	30%

These findings underscore the critical need for enhanced engagement and retention strategies specifically targeting the contractual workforce, which is the primary segment driving overall attrition at the plant.

CHAPTER 8 FINDINGS

Recruitment Outcomes and Early Attrition Analysis

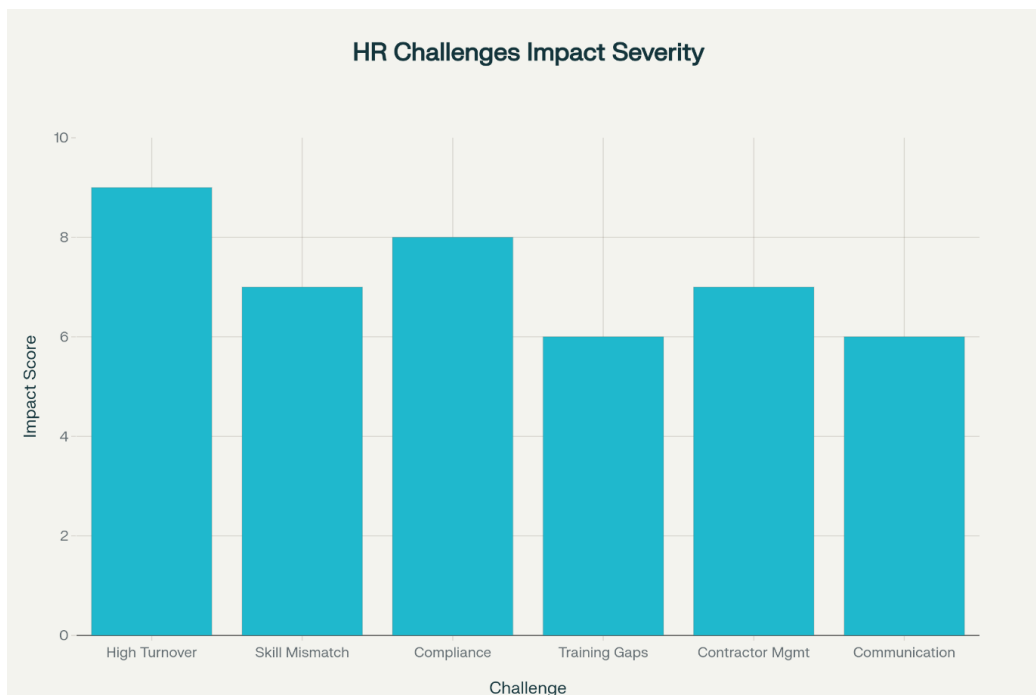
During the recruitment drive at Farms2Freeze, a total of 50 candidates were interviewed for various positions. Of these, offer letters were sent to 35 candidates based on suitability and alignment with job requirements. However, 5 candidates declined the offer, opting for other opportunities that better matched their career aspirations. Additionally, there were 5 instances of no-shows where candidates accepted the offer but failed to report for joining. Furthermore, among those who joined, 5 candidates resigned within the first two days citing misalignment with the organizational culture and job expectations. These trends highlight early attrition challenges and underscore the need for enhanced candidate screening, realistic job previews, and improved induction processes to increase retention.

Outcome	Number of Candidates	Percentage (%)
Offer Letters Sent	35	70
Offer Rejected	5	10
No Show after Acceptance	5	10
Joined but Left Early	5	10

- High turnover was observed among off-roll/contract workers, with many leaving within a week of joining without serving notice periods, affecting operational stability.
- Skill mismatches and lack of adequate hands-on training were identified as key reasons behind recruitment challenges, especially among shopfloor and technical staff.
- Compliance enforcement related to statutory benefits (PF, ESI), plant safety, and hygiene SOPs sometimes increased short-term attrition but was essential for regulatory adherence.
- Digital tools like HRCONNECKT improved record accuracy and payroll processing but required enhanced user training to minimize manual errors and delays.
- Employee engagement and induction programs were effective in raising safety and policy awareness but required expansion in vernacular communication for better reach among blue-collar and contract workers.
- Contractor dependence introduced challenges such as inconsistent screening, limited accountability, and varied compliance adherence.
- Strong cross-functional coordination between HR, production, and QA teams was necessary to streamline recruitment, retain talent, and comply with industry standards.

The Six Key HR Challenges:

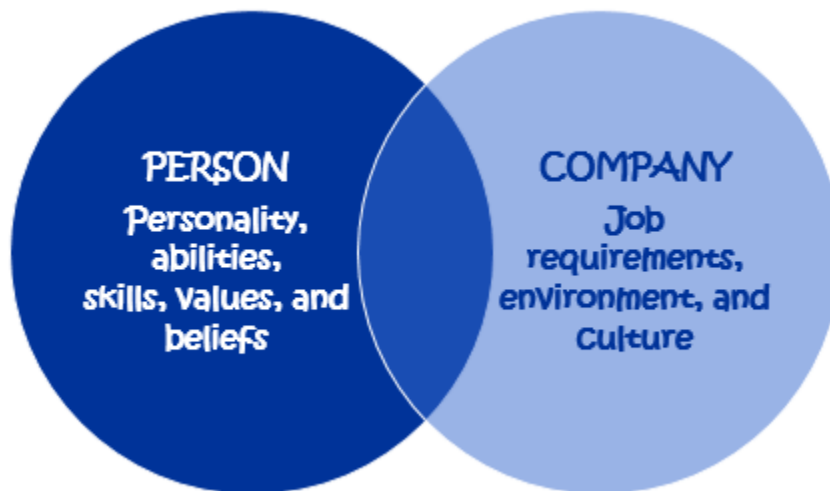
- 1. High turnover of off-roll workers (Severity = 9):**
The highest impact challenge. Due to reliance on contract and off-roll labor with frequent early exits and notice period breaches, causing operational instability and repeated recruitment cycles.
- 2. Compliance issues (Severity = 8):**
Stringent statutory compliance (PF, ESI, safety, hygiene) sometimes causes resistance and short-term attrition, especially among semi-skilled or contract staff unfamiliar with formal processes.
- 3. Skill mismatch (Severity = 7):**
Frequent mismatches between candidate capabilities and role requirements, particularly for technical shopfloor roles, leading to training challenges and early attrition.
- 4. Contractor management issues (Severity = 7):**
Dependency on contractors creates variations in training quality, compliance adherence, and accountability, adding complexity to workforce stability.
- 5. Induction and training gaps (Severity = 6):**
Gaps in onboarding quality, language barriers, and inadequate training delivery affect employee understanding and compliance with SOPs.
- 6. Communication breakdown (Severity = 6):**
Poor cross-functional communication and limited engagement with contract/blue-collar workers impact clarity, motivation, and retention.



CHAPTER 9 INTERNSHIP EXPERIENCE

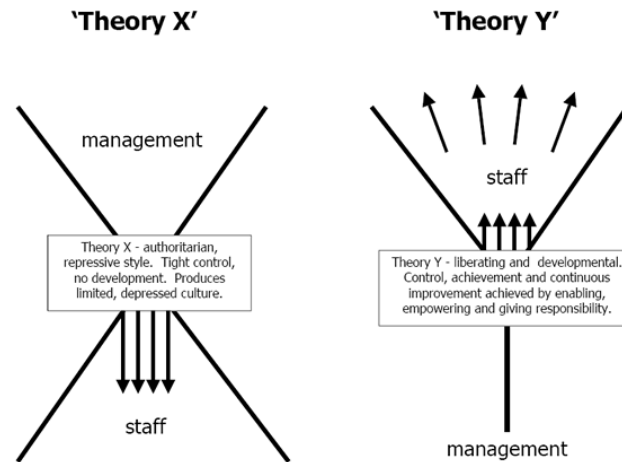
During my six-week internship at Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd., I took on a comprehensive HR role embedded within the plant environment. My primary responsibilities included assisting in the end-to-end recruitment process, screening over 100 candidate resumes, facilitating and coordinating more than 50 interviews, and ensuring smooth onboarding and induction for 20+ new hires. Additionally, I managed and updated personnel records, digitizing more than 60 employee files to improve accessibility and compliance audit readiness. I was actively involved in coordinating training sessions, maintaining HR databases, developing MIS reports, supporting the performance management system, and conducting regular safety, hygiene, and compliance inspections across the shop floor. My role also extended to organizing employee engagement campaigns, supporting performance appraisals, handling documentation for statutory compliance, and collaborating across departments such as production, quality, and stores. I noticed that all the theories that I have been taught in college were perfectly applied in the real-world scenario also, some of them are:

Job Fit Theory (Person-Job Fit):



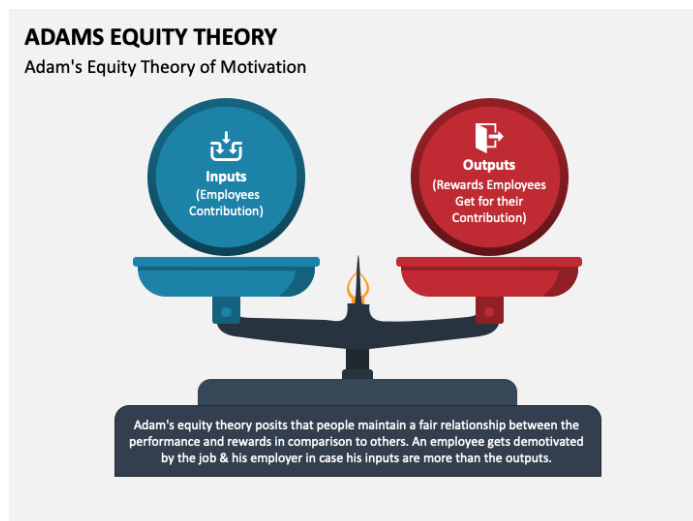
This theory recognizes that optimal performance and satisfaction occur when there is alignment between an individual's skills and the job's requirements. Practically, I applied this by closely mapping candidate backgrounds to detailed job descriptions—particularly vital for technical shopfloor roles—to ensure better role fit, reduce early attrition (a key challenge), and foster long-term engagement.

McGregor's Theory X and Theory Y:



These theories describe management's assumptions about worker motivation. On the floor, Theory Y (trust in employees' self-motivation and responsibility) proved effective in empowering shopfloor supervisors and experienced operators, leading to better compliance with SOPs and safety standards. Conversely, initial onboarding of new or contract workers sometimes necessitated Theory X oversight—constant supervision, clear directives—until they adapted to plant discipline and expectations.

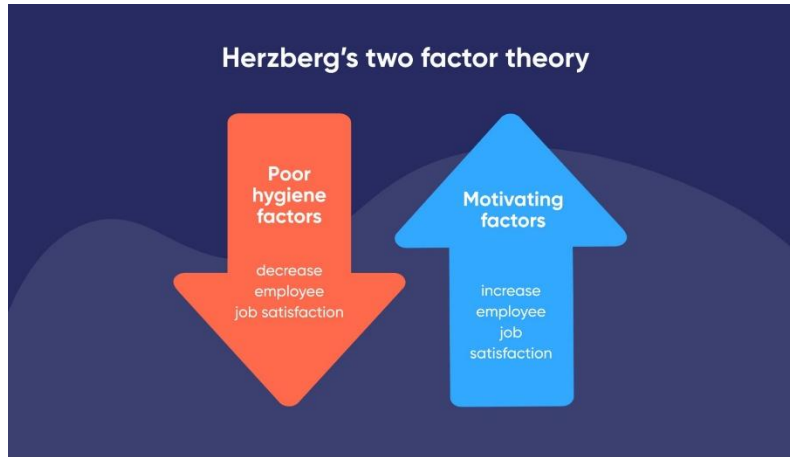
Equity Theory and Organizational Justice:



Equity theory highlights employee motivation related to fairness in treatment and rewards. By ensuring transparency in bonus policies, equal access to training, and consistent application of statutory benefits (PF, ESI), I helped mitigate perceptions of injustice, especially among off-

roll workers. Regular communication and visible grievance mechanisms fostered trust and reduced workplace friction.

Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory:

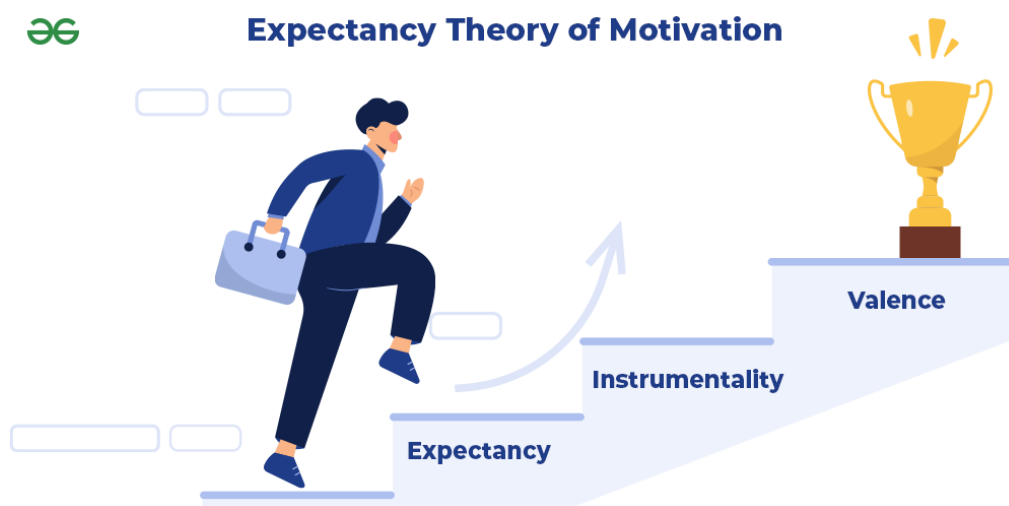


Hygiene factors (salary, working conditions, safety) and motivators (recognition, advancement) both shaped my handling of induction and engagement. Employees voiced satisfaction when induction covered hygiene issues like safety protocols and workplace facilities, and responded positively to feedback sessions recognizing individual contributions.

Ethical HR Policies:

Throughout, ethical considerations governed decision-making—confidentiality of employee information, fairness in opportunity, non-discrimination during recruitment, and honest communication. We adhered to the company's code of conduct, promoted inclusivity, and ensured all HR processes reflected integrity and transparency, critical for industrial harmony.

Vroom's Expectancy Theory:



Vroom's Expectancy Theory posits that individuals are motivated when they believe their efforts will lead to good performance (expectancy), which will in turn yield desirable rewards (instrumentality), and those rewards are personally meaningful (valence).

At Farms2Freeze, this was evident in the design of incentive structures—such as attendance-based bonuses, production-linked recognitions, and opportunities for permanent roles for contract staff. Communication during induction made it clear how consistent performance or adherence to safety protocols would result in tangible rewards, which employees valued. As a result, shopfloor workers were motivated to meet targets and comply with SOPs, knowing that these efforts led to both recognition and advancement.

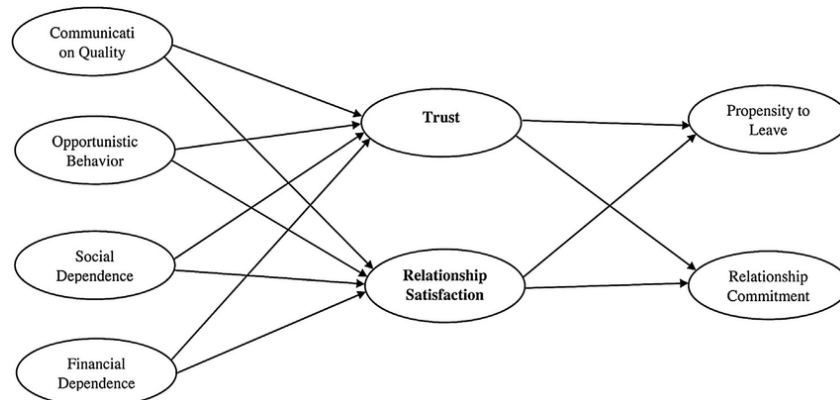
Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs:



Maslow's hierarchy of needs

Maslow's model classifies human motivation into a five-tier hierarchy: physiological, safety, belonging, esteem, and self-actualization needs. Lower needs must be met before higher ones motivate behavior.

HR practices at Farms2Freeze addressed all tiers, including ensuring wages were paid on time, ensuring periods of pay had safe working conditions (physiological and safety) to developing team engagement through induction programs, and recognition throughout plant meetings (belonging and esteem). By enabling experienced workers to lead Kaizen quality circles or improvement projects, the company promoted self-actualization, motivating senior staff to go beyond the minimum requirements and embrace leadership roles.

Social Exchange Theory:

According to this theory, social behavior in organizations stems from an exchange process -- satisfaction and retention are the result of mutual commitment, respect, and support. By providing frequent, two-way feedback avenues (suggestion boxes, open HR-employee interactions), Farms2Freeze, built an atmosphere where employees felt listened to and supported. This reciprocity encouraged greater ownership, voluntary adherence to safety norms, and willingness to support the onboarding of new hires, thus positively influencing plant morale and retention.

Operational Exposure and Theories

My experience extended to daily collaboration with production, quality, stores, and maintenance departments:

Kaizen (Continuous Improvement) in Operations:

Inspired by lean manufacturing principles, I participated in small process improvement initiatives (e.g., updating shift rosters with plant heads, helping introduce digital checklists for PPE compliance) which encouraged a culture of incremental, employee-driven

enhancements. I observed and facilitated several plant-floor initiatives—like digitalizing PPE checklists and updating shift rosters—where workers were encouraged to propose operational enhancements. This culture led to measurable improvements in safety compliance and productivity, with employees taking pride in their contributions to process efficiency.

Total Quality Management (TQM):



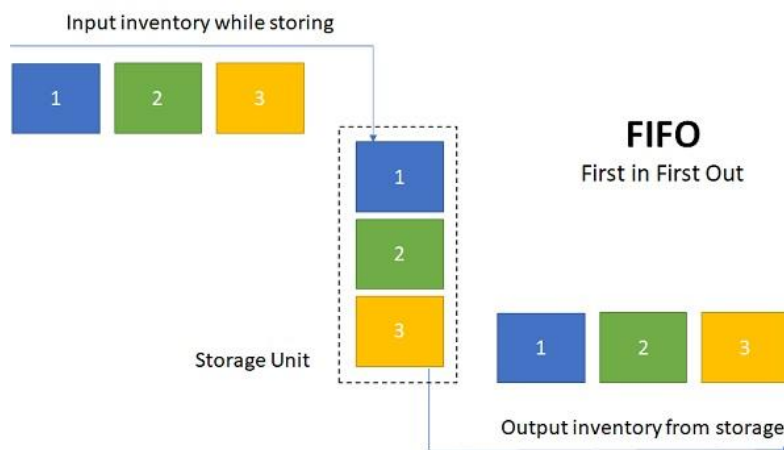
By assisting QA with shop floor observations, I learned TQM's core idea—organizational commitment to quality at every level. Engagement campaigns and safety drills reflected TQM's emphasis on employee involvement in process quality. Quality Assurance (QA) activities at Farms2Freeze, such as joint HR-production safety inspections and routine shopfloor audits, reflected TQM's ethos. Employee engagement campaigns (safety drills, hygiene workshops) promoted broad participation in upholding quality, making it a shared responsibility and improving overall plant output.

5S Workplace Organization:

1		SORT Remove all items that are not used or needed in the work area.	"When in doubt, move it out!"
2		SET IN ORDER Find the best location for remaining items, set inventory limits, and place temporary labels, lines and signboards.	"A place for everything and everything in its place!"
3		SHINE Clean, repair, and paint everything, inside and out. Prevent dirt, grime, and contamination from reoccurring. Inspect while cleaning.	"Make it clean and keep it clean"
4		STANDARDIZE Write 5S SWIS for maintaining and controlling the first 3.	"Quality processes on time every time!"
5		SUSTAIN With Management support, use 5S Board, Monthly audits and recognition.	"The most difficult – just do it!"

Principles of Sort, Set in order, Shine, Standardize, and Sustain were evident in the plant's daily housekeeping routines. Participation in 5S audits showed how operational discipline improves safety and morale—HR's support in training reinforced this culture. Daily 5S audits, in which I participated, led to cleaner, more navigable production areas and improved storage of raw materials and finished goods. HR supported 5S by incorporating the principles into onboarding and ongoing training, which reduced clutter, minimized hazards, and increased worker morale.

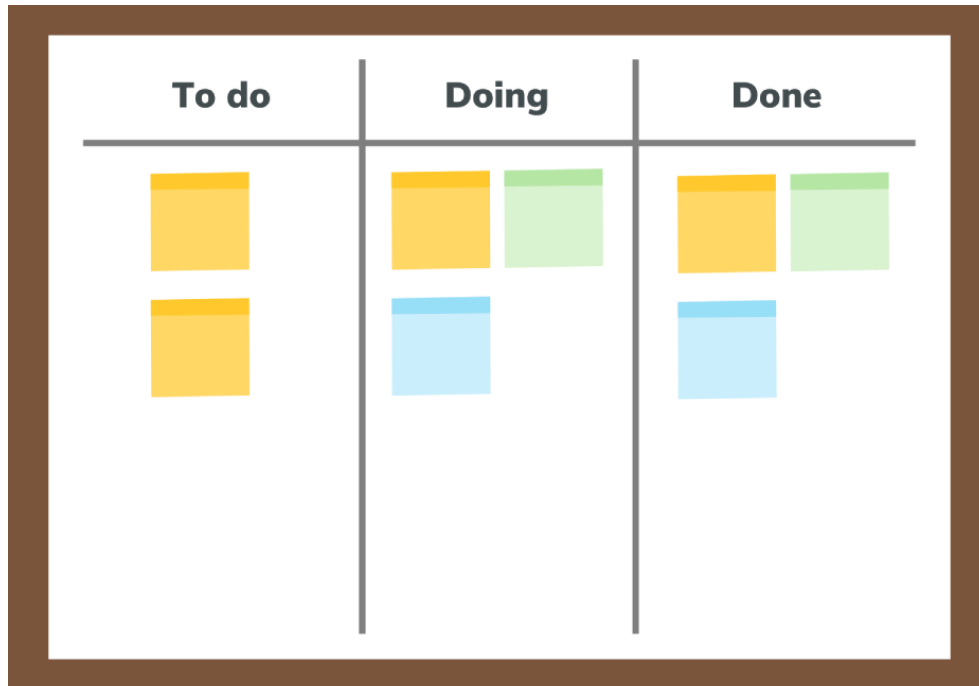
FIFO (First-In, First-Out):



FIFO is an inventory management principle where the earliest received materials are used or dispatched first, minimizing wastage and ensuring product freshness. On the shop floor, particularly in cold storage and raw ingredient management, I observed and supported the FIFO

system's enforcement. HR aided stores and quality teams by communicating FIFO protocols during training, reducing spoilage, ensuring compliance with food safety audits, and supporting seamless operations in line with best manufacturing practices.

Kanban:

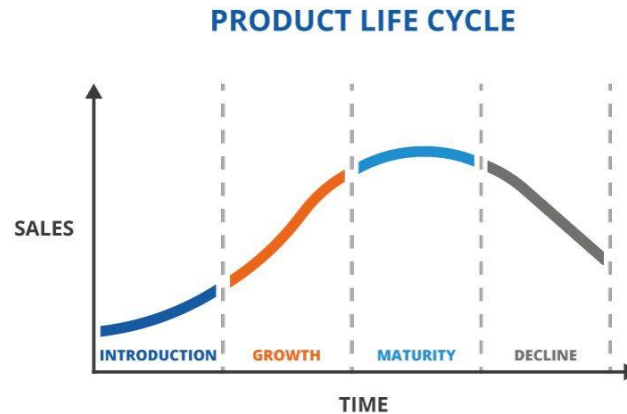


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Kanban is a visual workflow management tool/technique that signals production needs—often using cards or markers—to balance workloads and prevent overproduction or bottlenecks. As part of my exposure to plant operations, I saw Kanban boards being used to track batch progress and material movement. HR's role was to facilitate training on Kanban use and to organize labor around these visual cues, ensuring the right number of employees were scheduled at each production stage. This reduced downtime, improved shift readiness, and reinforced cross-functional coordination.

Product Mix and Marketing Insights

Exposure to the product portfolio (samosa, paratha, tikki, etc.) deepened my understanding of marketing and product management within FMCG:

Product Life Cycle (PLC):

I observed how the introduction of new items (e.g., specialty breads or healthier snacks) required coordinated HR efforts for training and upskilling, aligning with the 'Growth' stage of the PLC. The HR role supported smooth scaling by managing learning curves among workers. At Farms2Freeze, I was involved in HR efforts during the “Growth” phase of launching new products—like innovative paratha or tikki variants. As production ramped up, speedy onboarding and targeted training as well as flexibility in labor assignment were crucial in achieving quality and accommodating additional demand—a concrete illustration of HR's strategic function in enabling both operations and marketing goals in the product life cycle (PLC).

Marketing Mix (4Ps):

Product: My work instilled understanding of quality standards for each product line for employees which assisted in delivering a consistent, reliable product to market.

Place: Working with stores and logistics to ensure smooth movement of manpower allocation, directly connected to distribution.

Promotion: Employee engagement campaigns stressed proud participation as part of product quality which promoted brand ownership.

Price: HR communicated transparent wage system and incentive initiatives, which helped align internal stakeholders to the company's value proposition.

Challenges, Solutions, and Practical Application

- **High Attrition Among Off-Roll Employees:**
The figures indicated a high level of off-roll turnover. I improved onboarding, clearly set expectations, and increased support in the first week—my rationale drew upon job fit and expectancy theories to inspire retention.
- **Skill Gaps and Compliance Resistance:**
Insufficient hands-on skills and reluctance to adhere to safety/SOPs were common among new hires. We addressed this by focusing on behavioral training (drawing on Theory Y, treating employees as capable of learning and self-discipline), offering recognition for compliance improvements, and using bilingual materials to bridge communication gaps.

Skills Developed and Lessons Learned

- Built advanced interview scheduling, resume screening, and induction facilitation abilities.
- Gained practical knowledge of statutory compliance and the integration of HRMS platforms like HRKconnect.
- Enhanced data management competencies through the digitization of over 60 employee records.
- Developed a cross-functional lens by working directly with production, quality, and NPD, learning the interconnectedness of HR, operations, and marketing in FMCG.

Analysis, Reflection and Professional Growth

Academically learned HR strategies were brought to life via daily plant realities:

- **Bridging Theory and Practice:** Equity and motivation theories were directly relevant to the attrition and engagement challenges I faced. Kaizen and TQM principles showed the value of HR in facilitating continuous improvement on the shop floor.
- **Strengths:** Developed strong communication, process orientation, adaptability to plant demands, and proficiency in HR digital tools.

- Areas for Growth: Further improvement needed in advanced HR analytics (e.g., Power BI, dashboarding), strategic HRM (talent pipeline building), conflict management, and independent project leadership.

Industry Insights and Career Impact

The internship provided firsthand insight into the complexity and dynamism of the FMCG manufacturing sector in India. It highlighted the necessity of blending HR best practices, OB principles, operational efficiency, and ethical conduct to achieve plant stability and growth. I saw the interconnectedness of HR with a series of other roles—production flow, quality assurance, employee engagement, and brand equity are all related in complex ways. This exposure has well-prepared me for a career based on strategic, equitable, and operationally sound HR practice.

CHAPTER 10 KEY CHALLENGES IN TALENT ACQUISITION WITHIN THE INDIAN FMCG MANUFACTURING SECTOR

In the Indian FMCG manufacturing sector, talent acquisition is complex and multi-faceted due to the operational requirements of the sector, the appropriation of a diverse workforce, and the changing industry standards. During my internship at Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd, a significant player in this sector, I learned how to observe firsthand the various complexities included in these intersectionalities. Besides direct observations when I was practically involved with the talent acquisition process and when I analysed the data for a further review, I have noted the critical actors to effective talent acquisition and significant barriers which require full strategic responses.

1. Skill Shortage and Candidate-Job Mismatch

One of the most critical challenges facing FMCG manufacturing is the significant gap between the available candidates' skillsets and the technical and operational requirements of the roles. The plant's semi-urban location limits the available talent pool to mostly candidates from surrounding areas, who are often not exposed to the sophisticated manufacturing technologies, automation, and quality standards needed for this sector. The gap in skillsets causes early attrition, production disruptions, and higher training costs. There is a need for improved candidate screening selection processes which incorporate the Job Fit Theory—this means that recruitment focuses on candidates' potential or how well their skills match the specific job requirements.

2. High Dependency on Off-Roll and Contract Workers

Flexibility in managing personnel is one of the key elements of manufacturing sites such as Farms2Freeze which utilize contract and off-roll labour to accommodate variations in production cycles. However, this also presents challenges and there is a range of issues one faces with flexible labour: firstly, high turn over rate where many contract staff leave as soon as they start work and quite often without notice; training consistency; and poor adherence to statutory compliance. This continuously moving workforce clearly disrupts production and being confronted with repeated recruitment processes and onboarding costs is frustrating for HR practitioners. To manage this workforce contractors are ultimately going to need to be made more accountable, a more comprehensive induction programme will be needed with consistent engagement activities planned for these transient workers.

3. Compliance and Regulatory Challenges Influencing Retention

The adherence to compliance with statutory policies and regulations (like PF, ESI, safety policies, plant hygiene SOPs, etc.) is key to run moral and legal operation. Ironically, adherence to compliance leads to workforce churn. Workers who are inexperienced with formal safety policies and documentation requirements will feel overwhelmed, and they may make the choice to disengage, or worse - quit. In many cases language issues become a barrier to effective communication of these policies, especially with blue-collar and off-roll employees. This

situation calls for multi-lingual and culturally relevant onboarding and training approaches along with supportive supervision to inspire, rather than penalize the compliance process.

4. Inadequate Employer Branding and Perceived Job Attractiveness

Plant-based manufacturing roles have generally held a poor perception when placed in contrast to corporate FMCG roles. Manufacturing roles at plants have also struggled with perception due to poor working conditions, strict shifts, and the limited view of professional growth. This perception creates a mismatch in establishing brand value which in turn reduces the amount of suitable candidates seeking long-term commitment within the industry. The sector has also had to deal with competition at this point from other industries offering an improved pay rate, or restrictive working conditions. From my work experience, it became apparent that establishing a solid employer value proposition - a lens into career and development pathways, strong workplace safety practices, ethical obligations, and training - was key to attracting suitable workers, as well as retaining engaged workers..

5. Coordinated Cross-Functional Communication and Process Integration

Talent acquisition in manufacturing is not limited to HR's function, but rather requires collaborative efforts from HR people, production managers, quality teams and contractors. My focus on the day-to-day operations with a hands-on approach allowed me to clearly see how the many misalignments between these groups created delays in the hiring process, negatively impacted the candidate experience and hampered the accuracy of workforce planning. While software programs like HRKconnect improve compliance and data integrity, they need to be supported by real-time communication elements and shared accountability to be truly effective.

The challenges I identified are all interrelated issues, and such challenges require an altogether way of thinking about a more effective and multi-faceted HR strategy, that encompasses far more than just recruitment. The talent acquisition process needs to include workforce planning, and skills development partnerships with vocational institutes and local educational training centres, improvement to candidate and job seeker experience through employer branding practices, and improved onboarding accountability processes before speaking about the need to have the right processes in plant operations that support a culture of equity, transparency and continuous improvement as retaining great talent and operational excellence has to happen together.

Elimination of all these barriers means organizations such as Farms2Freeze are better positioned to build a flexible, competent and compliant workforce with an ongoing need for skilled labour force to support sustained growth in India's fast paced and competitive FMCG manufacturing environment.

CHAPTER 11 CONCLUSION

The hands-on experience at Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd. taught me that theories and best practices learned in class represent just the tip of the iceberg; something FMCG plants have to diligently and effectively put into action. The internship also helped me appreciate the HR department in an organization and how it helps integrate strategy, operations, and culture for the organization. I also directly saw the HR challenges and the striking need to integrate theory and practice for enhancing organizational performance through multiple functions—talent acquisition, onboarding, and training, to name a few, to record digitization, compliance management, and interdepartmental collaboration.

The reliance on Job Fit Theory was pivotal to the plant's ability to reduce attrition and boost engagement, particularly when hiring for shopfloor roles where early turnover had been a recurring issue. Similarly, applying McGregor's Theory X and Theory Y approaches simultaneously allowed for both discipline and empowerment, adjusting managing techniques to worker readiness and maturity. Identifying and Supporting Workplace Equity as Suggested by Equity Theory and Organizational Justice Principles Positively Influenced Employee Satisfaction and Trust in Mixed Groups of Permanent and Contract Workers.

Herzberg's Two-Factor Theory emphasized the importance of hygiene factors like safety, fair compensation, and working conditions, while also noting the impact of motivation and employee recognition on productivity and morale. Ethical HR policies were a foundation for building a culture of transparency, inclusivity, and trust—essential elements for enduring stability and employer branding in a competitive industry.

From an operational standpoint, this experience showcased the impressive overlap of HR with operational frameworks like Kaizen, total quality management, and 5S. Continuous improvement initiatives, quality audits, and attempts to standardize processes offered a vivid picture of how HR policies support engagement, compliance, and plant safety, transforming a theoretical idea into a hands-on, lasting transformation.

My understanding of the product mix and marketing strategy enlightened me on the ways HR supports the company's market goals beyond just hiring and training. It is the nurture of an engaged, knowledgeable workforce that serves as brand ambassadors at every point of product interaction.

The realities of the workplace - high off-roll attrition and mismatched skilling - meant that it was important to achieve a series of carefully considered, theory and evidence based interentions. For eg: undertaking to shore up onboarding, strengthen behavioural training and improve communication via vernacular language. These experiences deepened my technical HR toolkit and I would say also expanded my soft skills in terms of communication skills, adaptability and collaborative practice. In terms of reflecting on my development, I showed strengths in process orientation, being able to work with cross functional teams, digital HR

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expertise and continuing to learn at a proactive level. The areas for growth including advanced analytics, strategic HRM and conflict resolution are developed and priorities that I will embark upon professionally. Overall, this internship connected my classroom learning with the real complexities of HR in the Indian FMCG sector. It helped me realise that HR plays an integral role as both a strategic and operational partner that underpins compliance, organizational culture, innovation and, adaptability. This internship experience further entrenched my determination to have a career that can facilitate ethical-evidence based HR which also furthers, not only the business objectives of an organization, but employee growth and wellbeing as a whole. The experience in Farms2Freeze Foods Pvt. Ltd. will teach. can be a strong base to make contributions to organizations under the constantly changing circumstances. of talent acquisition, workforce management, and sustainable growth in the FMCG landscape.

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